



ON THE RUN:
Kumar

A Gurgaon doctor's ruthless racket in kidney transplants reveals how India has once again become a major bazaar for illegal trade in human body parts

THE KIDNEY MAFIA

■ By Damayanti Datta

He is now regarded as the diabolical kingpin of the trade in illegal kidney transplants in India and Dr Amit Kumar does look the part. "There is something particularly chilling about him, even when he lounges with wine and women," say people who have known him. It doesn't help that his hooded, close-set eyes make his default expression broody and watchful. Or that his thin mouth, even when he cosies up for a family snap in his plush Canada home, seems closed in on itself. Being the honorific "son of a freedom fighter"

does nothing to dispel the image of evil. He is a physician who doesn't care for the Hippocratic Oath of, "first, do no harm". His brutal ventures cause visceral revulsion (his father disowned him, his first wife broke up with him and his relatives refuse to acknowledge him). Such is the national furore caused by his illegal actions that Anbumani Ramadoss, minister of health, asserts, "We are asking CBI to probe the issue. We are also determined to go ahead with an amendment to the existing organs transplant Act to plug the loopholes and make it more transparent. We plan to establish donor banks across the country to raise awareness."

January 24 would have been just another day for Kumar, but for that phone call around midnight, tipping him off about a possible police raid. Life was good till then. He was just back from Canada, his gorgeous Greek girlfriend had fixed up a kidney recipient rich enough to cough up Rs 20 lakh for a transplant and three *pappus*—code word for a victim—had been stripped of a kidney each in three days, the last one just a few hours back and still in bed.

If Kumar didn't worry about the tip

75 per cent of all kidn